

International Football Dataset

A Data Visualization Report

Source: Kaggle | Period: 1872 to 2026

1. Overview

This report presents a visual analysis of international football match data spanning more than 150 years, from 1872 to 2026. The dataset covers results from competitive tournaments, qualification rounds, regional cups, and friendlies across nations worldwide. The goal is to understand how the game has evolved, which nations dominate, and what patterns emerge around scoring and home advantage.

All charts referenced in this report are compiled in the Appendix at the end of the document, labelled as Figures 1 through 9.

2. Match Volume Over Time

International football started slow. Before 1900, very few matches were recorded, and the sport remained largely confined to Europe. Things picked up gradually through the early 20th century, but the two World Wars left clear dips in the data. Activity dropped sharply during 1914 to 1918 and again during 1939 to 1945, as expected.

The real explosion came after 1950. Decolonisation brought dozens of new footballing nations onto the scene, and continental qualification tournaments began expanding rapidly. By the modern era, the world was seeing 1,000 to 2,000+ international matches every single year, compared to near-zero in the 1870s.

Looking at the breakdown by tournament type, Qualifications and Friendlies account for the bulk of this growth. The COVID-19 dip in 2020 is visible but brief. Matches quickly resumed, many played in empty stadiums, and the numbers bounced back almost immediately the following year.

(See Figure 1 in the Appendix)

3. Who Wins? Home, Draw, or Away

Across all international matches in history, home teams win close to 49% of the time. Away teams manage just 28%. That is a 21-point gap, and it holds up consistently across eras. This is not random variance; it is a structural feature of the sport.

The neutral venue chart makes this even clearer. When matches are played at a neutral ground, the home win rate drops to around 45% while away wins climb to roughly 34%. The gap nearly halves. That single comparison is strong evidence that the advantage is venue-driven, not simply a reflection of the better team playing at home.

Breaking it down by tournament tier, qualification rounds show the highest home advantage at around 51%. This makes sense as those matches are played in home stadiums before passionate local crowds, often against regional opponents. Major Finals, typically held at neutral venues, show a slightly lower home win rate of about 46%.

The draw rate stays remarkably steady across all tiers, hovering around 22 to 25%. Draws appear to be a natural feature of football rather than something driven by tournament context.

(See Figure 2 in the Appendix)

4. Goals Distribution

Football is a low-scoring sport, and the numbers confirm it. About 73% of all international matches produce three or fewer total goals. The most common outcome is a two-goal game, which happens in 22% of matches. Goalless games (0-0) account for 8% of all results, which is more frequent than any scoreline involving five or more total goals.

When we separate home and away scoring, the gap shows up again. Away teams score zero goals far more often than home teams, while home teams dominate the one and two-goal bins. In high-scoring matches, though, this gap disappears. Venue advantage seems to matter most when both teams are relatively evenly matched, and the game stays tight.

(See Figure 3 in the Appendix)

5. Most Common Scorelines

The most common scorelines across all of football history are 1-0, 1-1, and 0-0, in that order. The 1-0 result has occurred over 5,000 times. What also stands out is the clear asymmetry between mirror scorelines. A 2-0 home win has happened nearly twice as often as a 0-2 away win. A 2-1 home win appears far more frequently than a 1-2 away win. These numbers quantify home advantage directly at the scoreline level.

(See Figure 4 in the Appendix)

6. Home Advantage Across the Decades

Home win rates have sat at roughly 50% for over a century. Away win rates settled at 25 to 27%. That gap has not meaningfully changed since the 1950s. Home advantage in international football is not fading over time. It appears to be structural.

What has changed is the draw rate. It climbed from around 9% in the early 20th century to about 23% in recent decades. The gains in draws are largely coming at the expense of away wins. As

defensive tactics improved and became more sophisticated, away sides became harder to beat, but they also became less able to win.

The neutral venue data reinforces the same point. Remove the home ground, and the win rates for both sides converge toward 35 to 40%. That is not a coincidence. It is proof that the advantage is about the venue, the crowd, and the familiarity, not just about which team is technically better.

(See Figure 5 in the Appendix)

7. Top Nations by Win Rate and Goals

Among nations that have played at least 100 matches, Brazil leads the win rate chart at approximately 63.5%, followed by Spain at around 58.9% and Germany at roughly 58%. These numbers align closely with what football history would suggest about the world's elite teams.

Some smaller nations like Jersey and Guernsey appear near the top, but their records consist mostly of matches against weaker opposition, which inflates their win rate. Among nations with large, diverse match histories, Brazil, Spain, and Germany are the clear leaders.

Iran, at around 56.9%, is the most surprising legitimate entry in this group. It reflects decades of quiet dominance within Asian football that often goes unrecognised globally.

The goals chart tells a slightly different story. England leads in total goals scored simply because they have been playing international football the longest and has accumulated an enormous number of matches. Brazil, Germany, and Argentina all combine high win rates with high goal counts, which is the real hallmark of an elite football nation. Spain sits lower on the goals chart despite a high win rate, which fits their well-known historical style of winning through possession and control rather than through high-scoring performances.

(See Figure 6 in the Appendix)

8. Most Active Nations

Sweden tops the activity chart with 1,099 matches. This is surprising for a nation not typically mentioned alongside Brazil or Germany, and it is largely explained by their historically heavy friendly schedule. England, Argentina, Brazil, and Germany all cluster tightly between 1,020 and 1,088 matches, which is more expected given their long footballing histories.

The more interesting question is whether playing more matches makes a team better. The data says no. Finland, Zambia, and Japan have all played over 800 matches but sit at win rates between 24% and 50%. Brazil played a similar volume and won nearly 63% of the time. Activity alone does not predict quality.

(See Figure 7 in the Appendix)

9. How Scoring Has Changed Over the Decades

The data tells a clear story about football's tactical evolution. Average goals per match were chaotic in the early years, sitting above 5 goals per game in the 1880s. That figure has fallen steadily to a stable level of around 2.7 goals per match post-1990.

High-scoring matches, defined as those with four or more goals, have dropped from 62% of all games in the 1880s to under 30% in the modern era. Home teams have consistently outscored away teams in every decade, but away goal counts have fallen harder over time, which again reflects the growing preference for defensive organisation among teams playing on the road.

The rise of 0-0 draws from under 2% of matches to nearly 10% in recent decades confirms this defensive shift. Football went from an open, attacking game in its early years to a tactically disciplined, low-scoring sport by the modern era. The 1950s through the 1970s appear to be the period when this transition took hold.

(See Figure 8 in the Appendix)

10. Tournament Breakdown

Friendlies make up the largest share of raw match volume at roughly 19,000 games. However, they carry the least competitive weight. FIFA World Cup qualifying is far and away the biggest competitive competition with 8,771 matches, well ahead of UEFA Euro qualification at around 2,824 and AFCON qualification at roughly 2,327.

Qualification matches show the strongest home advantage, which is expected given they are played in home stadiums under high-pressure local conditions. Major Finals, often contested at neutral venues, show the lowest home advantage at around 46%.

Average goals are similar across all tournament tiers, hovering between 2.73 and 2.88 goals per match. Competitive pressure does not dramatically change how many goals are scored. It just changes who wins.

(See Figure 9 in the Appendix)

11. Summary

A few findings stand out clearly from this analysis. Home advantage is real, measurable, and has not declined over more than a century of international football. The gap between home and away win rates is approximately 21 percentage points, and neutral venue matches confirm this is driven by the venue itself, not just team quality.

Scoring has declined significantly over time as defensive tactics matured, with the modern game settling at roughly 2.7 goals per match compared to over 5 in the 1880s. The draw rate has risen steadily over the same period.

Among elite nations, Brazil, Germany, Spain, and Argentina consistently combine high win rates with high goal counts. The volume of matches played by a nation does not, on its own, predict quality.

Friendlies dominate the dataset numerically but carry the least signal about true team strength. Competitive matches, particularly qualification rounds, offer a much cleaner window into how nations actually perform under pressure.

Appendix: Charts and Visualizations

All figures referenced in this report are listed below in order.

Figure 1: Match Volume Over Time (1872 to 2026)

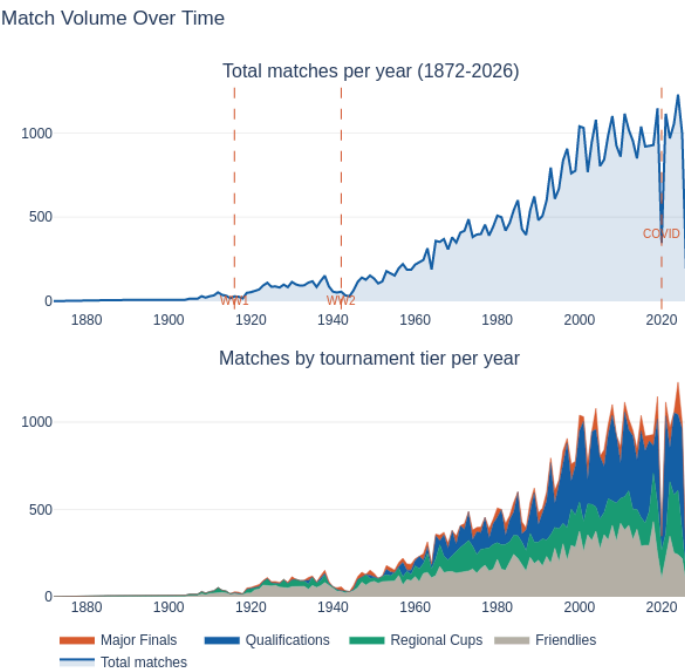


Figure 2: Result Split Analysis: Home Win, Draw, Away Win

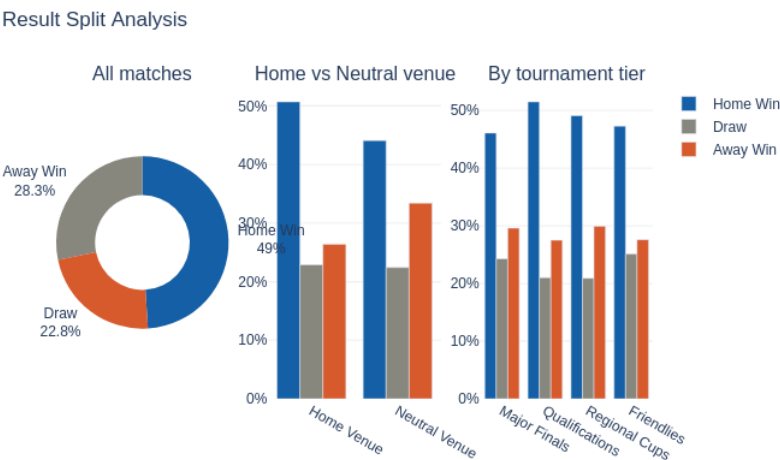


Figure 3: Goals Distribution per Match

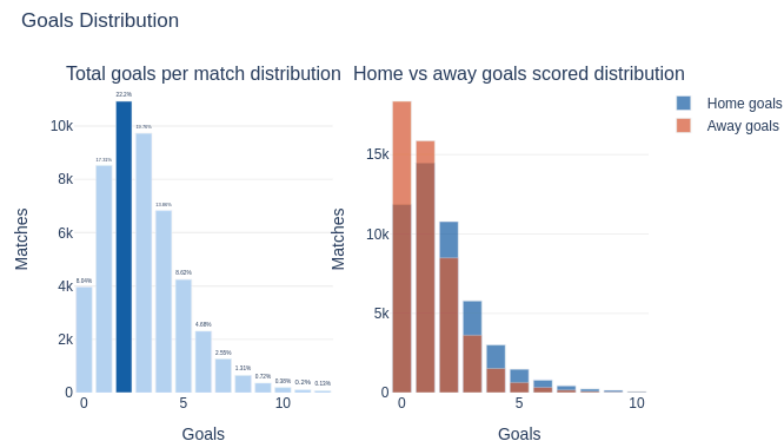


Figure 4: Top 15 Most Common Scorelines

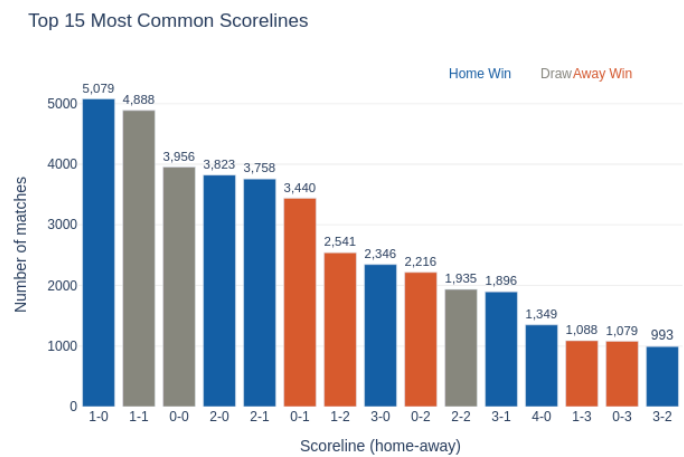


Figure 5: Home Advantage Trend by Decade

Home Advantage Analysis

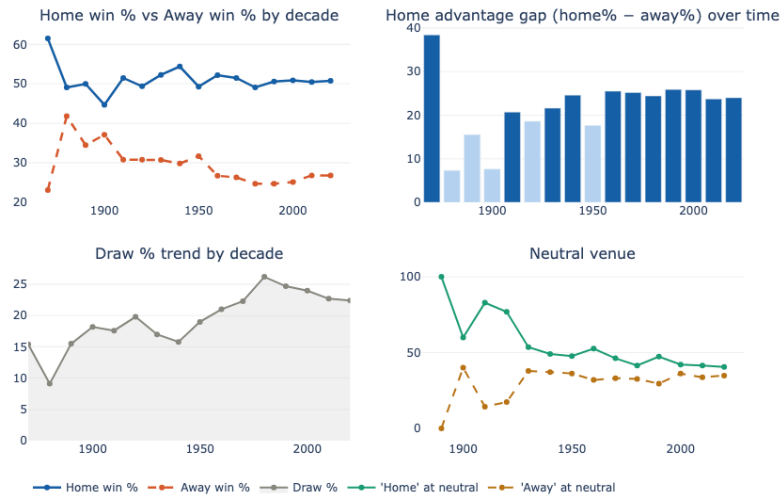


Figure 6: Top Nations by Win Rate and Goals Scored

Team Performance Overview

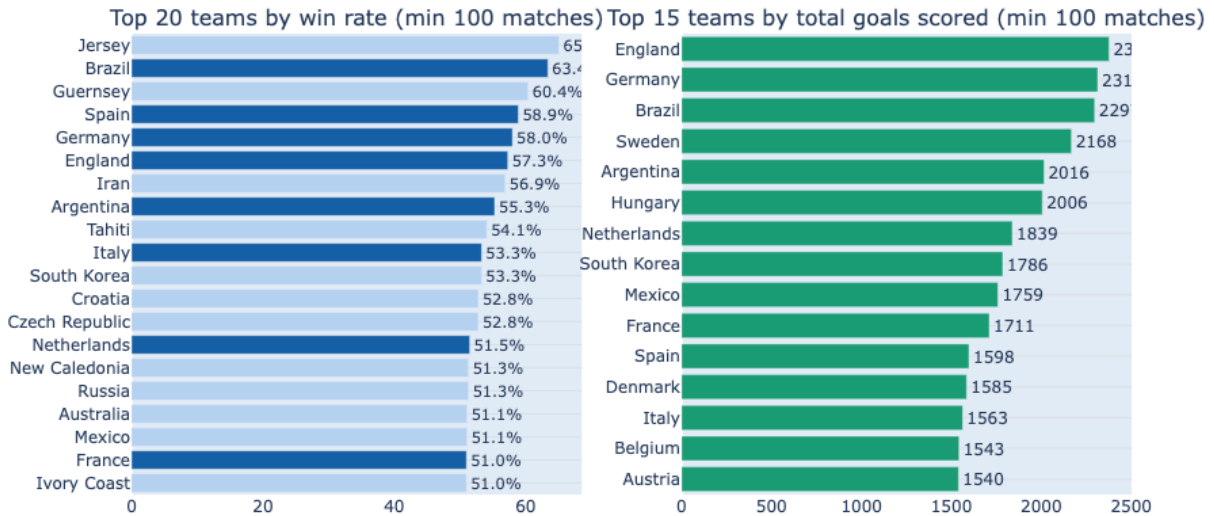
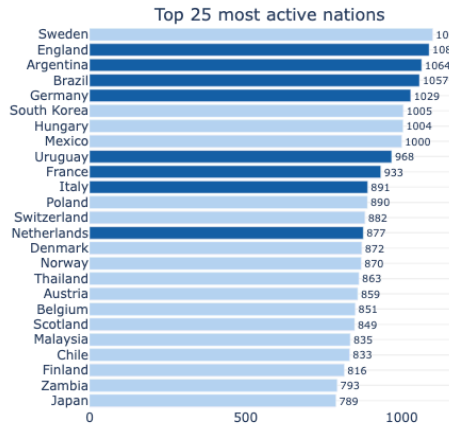


Figure 7: Most Active Nations: Activity vs Win Rate

Most Active Nations



Activity vs win rate

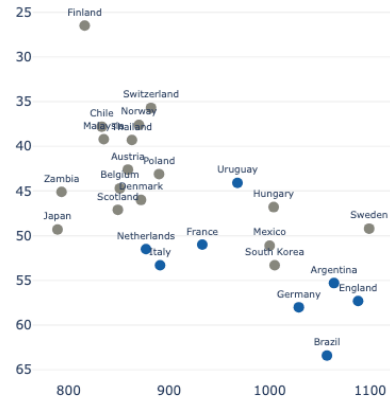


Figure 8: Goals Trend by Decade

Goals Trend Analysis

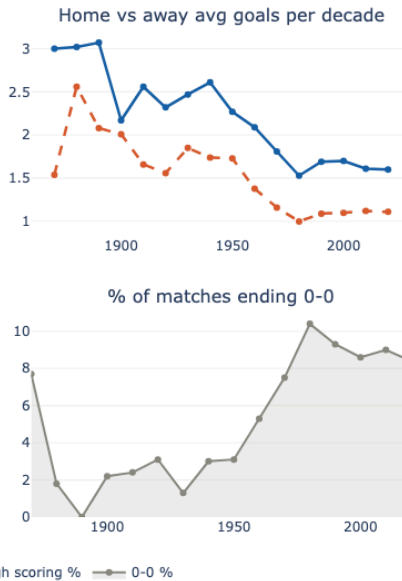
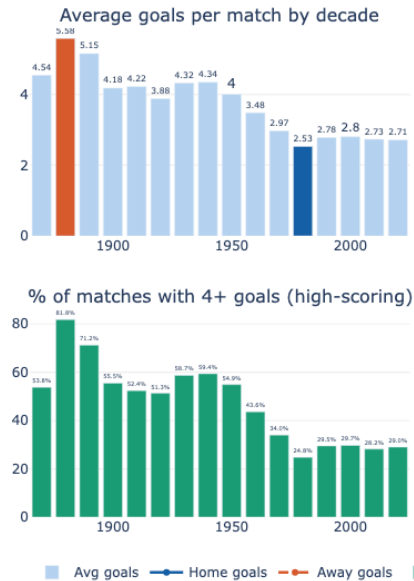


Figure 9: Tournament Breakdown by Match Count and Tier

Tournament Breakdown

